BRIGHTWATER HEALTH PLAN

Past Reviews Casebook

Document Casebook 01 | Issue 2 | Owner: Utilisation Management | Review cycle: every six months

1. About this casebook

Eight past reviews, one for each kind of evidence a reviewer meets, kept as worked examples of the Utilisation Management Policy and the medical policies in practice. Three screened as APPROVE and were approved by a UM Nurse Reviewer, one needed more information and four were referred to a Physician Reviewer. Each case records what was asked for, the answers as they were written and as the Prior Authorisation Rules read them, the evidence in the documents, each criterion's result, the decisions open and the outcome.

The casebook is confidential. It names members and requesting practices, is for Intake Coordinators, UM Nurse Reviewers and Physician Reviewers only, and is never quoted to a requesting office or a member.

Each case was reviewed under the medical policy of its own service. A criterion described in a case belongs to that service's policy and to no other, and a request is always reviewed under the current policy of its own service.

2. Conservative treatment: MRI of the lumbar spine

Mr Whitlock, aged 44, was referred by Thornton Rehabilitation Centre for an MRI scan of the lumbar spine. The request, PA-287314, arrived by fax and was marked standard.

The lumbar spine MRI policy applied: the member had to be 18 or over and to have had conservative treatment for six whole weeks unless a red flag was reported, and a scan of the lumbar spine less than twelve months old could be repeated only for new neurological symptoms.

The questionnaire gave the conservative treatment as 47 days (6 whole weeks); the red flag as None (No red flag); and the earlier scan of the region as No.

The physiotherapy report said: "Mr Whitlock has completed six weeks of physiotherapy and a home exercise programme." The physiotherapy report said: "He has had to give up lifting at work." The family physician letter said: "There is no saddle anaesthesia or sphincter disturbance."

- **Minimum age** - Met
- **Conservative treatment or red flag** - Met
- **Repeat imaging interval** - Met

The screening was APPROVE, and the decisions open were APPROVE and REFER TO PHYSICIAN.

A UM Nurse Reviewer approved the scan. The physiotherapy report's six weeks agreed with the questionnaire's whole weeks, so nothing was flagged.

3. Failed medication: Total knee replacement

Mrs Abernathy, aged 74, was referred by Northdale Highgate Orthopaedic Group for a total knee replacement. The request, PA-287562, arrived by the provider portal and was marked standard.

The knee replacement policy applied: the member had to be 18 or over, with an X-ray of Kellgren-Lawrence grade three or higher, conservative treatment for twelve whole weeks, an Oxford Knee Score of twenty-six or lower and a body mass index below forty.

The questionnaire gave the X-ray grade as KL grade 4 (4); the conservative treatment as 10 weeks (10 whole weeks); the Oxford Knee Score as 18/48 (18); the height as 5 ft 2 in (157.5 cm); the weight as 196 lb (88.9 kg); and the other conditions as Hypertension. The body mass index was 35.8.

The specialist letter said: "She has tried naproxen and tramadol without benefit." The specialist letter said: "Regular paracetamol has not controlled the pain." The physiotherapy report said: "Mrs Abernathy has had ten weeks of physiotherapy for the knee."

- **Minimum age** - Met
- **Radiographic severity** - Met
- **Conservative treatment** - Not met
- **Knee function** - Met

- **Body mass index** - Met

The screening was REFER TO PHYSICIAN, the only decision open.

The Physician Reviewer found that the failed medicines showed treatment had been tried but did not lengthen it, and denied the request after a peer-to-peer discussion with the surgeon. A new request after two more weeks of physiotherapy met every criterion and was approved.

4. Red-flag symptom: MRI of the cervical spine

Mr Ferraro, aged 63, was referred by Harbour Neurology Clinic for an MRI scan of the cervical spine. The request, PA-287905, arrived by the EDI feed and was marked urgent.

The cervical spine MRI policy applied: the member had to be 18 or over and to have had conservative treatment for four whole weeks unless a red flag was reported, and a scan of the cervical spine less than twelve months old could be repeated only for new neurological symptoms.

The questionnaire gave the conservative treatment as 8 days (1 whole week); the red flag as Progressive neuro deficit (Progressive neurological deficit); and the earlier scan of the region as No.

The specialist letter said: "Progressive weakness in the right arm has developed over the last two weeks." The specialist letter said: "Examination shows brisk reflexes in all four limbs, and I am concerned about cervical myelopathy."

- **Minimum age** - Met
- **Conservative treatment or red flag** - Met
- **Repeat imaging interval** - Met

The screening was APPROVE, and the decisions open were APPROVE and REFER TO PHYSICIAN.

Marked urgent, the request was decided within 72 hours: a UM Nurse Reviewer approved it on the red flag, which waived the length of treatment, and the scan was done the next morning.

5. Functional limitation: Total knee replacement

Mr Lindgren, aged 66, was referred by Westbridge Stonebridge Orthopaedic Clinic for a total knee replacement. The request, PA-288140, arrived by the provider portal and was marked standard.

The knee replacement policy applied: the member had to be 18 or over, with an X-ray of Kellgren-Lawrence grade three or higher, conservative treatment for twelve whole weeks, an Oxford Knee Score of twenty-six or lower and a body mass index below forty.

The questionnaire gave the X-ray grade as 3; the conservative treatment as 18 weeks (18 whole weeks); the Oxford Knee Score as 31/48 (31); the height as 180 cm; the weight as 94.0 kg; and the other conditions as None (No other conditions). The body mass index was 29.0.

The specialist letter said: "He walks with a stick and manages only 200 metres." The specialist letter said: "The knee gives way several times a week." The specialist letter said: "He has fallen twice when the knee gave way."

- **Minimum age** - Met
- **Radiographic severity** - Met
- **Conservative treatment** - Met
- **Knee function** - Not met
- **Body mass index** - Met

The screening was REFER TO PHYSICIAN, the only decision open.

The Physician Reviewer spoke with the surgeon: the score had been taken before the two falls, and the repeat score the surgeon sent after the call was 22. The criterion stayed Not met on the questionnaire's 31; the physician approved the request on the repeat score and the two falls, and recorded why.

6. Prior investigation: MRI of the lumbar spine

Mrs Castellanos, aged 52, was referred by Brookvale Pain Clinic for an MRI scan of the lumbar spine. The request, PA-288377, arrived by the provider portal and was marked standard.

The lumbar spine MRI policy applied: the member had to be 18 or over and to have had conservative treatment for six whole weeks unless a red flag was reported, and a scan of the lumbar spine less than twelve months old could be repeated only for new neurological symptoms.

The questionnaire gave the conservative treatment as 15 weeks (15 whole weeks); the red flag as No red flags (No red flag); the earlier scan of the region as Yes; the months since it as 9 months; and the new neurological symptoms as No.

The imaging report said: "A previous MRI nine months ago showed a disc protrusion at L4/5." The family physician letter said: "Neurological examination is normal, with no focal deficit."

- **Minimum age** - Met
- **Conservative treatment or red flag** - Met
- **Repeat imaging interval** - Not met

The screening was REFER TO PHYSICIAN, the only decision open.

The Physician Reviewer denied the repeat scan: nothing had changed since the scan nine months before, and the letter found no new deficit. The member continued physiotherapy.

7. Weight-management programme: Bariatric surgery

Ms Okonkwo, aged 39, was referred by Willowmere Weight Loss Surgery Centre for bariatric surgery. The request, PA-288621, arrived by the provider portal and was marked standard.

The bariatric surgery policy applied: the member had to be 18 or over, with a body mass index of forty or higher, or thirty-five or higher with hypertension, obstructive sleep apnoea or type 2 diabetes, six months in a supervised weight-management programme and a completed psychological assessment.

The questionnaire gave the height as 1.63 m (163.0 cm); the weight as 118.6 kg; the other conditions as OSA (Obstructive sleep apnoea); the programme as 5 months; and the psychological assessment as Completed. The body mass index was 44.6.

The dietitian report said: "Ms Okonkwo has seen the dietitian monthly for five months." The dietitian report said: "She has engaged well with dietary changes and the exercise plan."

- **Minimum age** - Met
- **Body mass index** - Met
- **Weight-management programme** - Not met
- **Psychological assessment** - Met

The screening was REFER TO PHYSICIAN, the only decision open.

The Physician Reviewer denied the request because the programme was a month short, and advised a new request once it reached six months. The new request met every criterion and was approved.

8. Other condition: Bariatric surgery

Mr Pemberton, aged 47, was referred by Larchmont Surgical Associates for bariatric surgery. The request, PA-288804, arrived by fax and was marked standard.

The bariatric surgery policy applied: the member had to be 18 or over, with a body mass index of forty or higher, or thirty-five or higher with hypertension, obstructive sleep apnoea or type 2 diabetes, six months in a supervised weight-management programme and a completed psychological assessment.

The questionnaire gave the height as 5 ft 7 in (170.2 cm); the weight as 16 st 8 lb (105.2 kg); the other conditions as HTN / GORD (Gastro-oesophageal reflux disease; Hypertension); the programme as 7 months; and the psychological assessment as Done (Completed). The body mass index was 36.3.

The surgical pre-assessment said: "He has hypertension on two medicines." The surgical pre-assessment said: "Known reflux disease, well controlled."

- **Minimum age** - Met
- **Body mass index** - Met
- **Weight-management programme** - Met

- **Psychological assessment** - Met

The screening was APPROVE, and the decisions open were APPROVE and REFER TO PHYSICIAN.

A UM Nurse Reviewer approved the request. Reflux disease is not a listed condition but hypertension is, and an index of 36.3 with a listed condition meets the criterion.

9. Ruled out: In-laboratory sleep study

Mr Nwachukwu, aged 58, was referred by Mill Lane Sleep Centre for an in-laboratory sleep study. The request, PA-289016, arrived by the provider portal and was marked standard.

The sleep study policy applied: the member had to be 18 or over with an Epworth score of ten or higher, and a laboratory study had to be needed: chronic obstructive pulmonary disease, heart failure or a neuromuscular disease, or a home test that was inconclusive or negative.

The questionnaire gave the Epworth score as 16/24 (16); the other conditions as Nil (No other conditions); and the home sleep test left blank.

The sleep clinic letter said: "He has no history of heart failure, COPD or neuromuscular disease." The sleep clinic letter said: "A home sleep apnoea test was negative despite a high clinical suspicion."

- **Minimum age** - Met
- **Daytime sleepiness** - Met
- **In-laboratory need** - Not documented

The screening was REQUEST MORE INFORMATION, and the decisions open were REQUEST MORE INFORMATION and REFER TO PHYSICIAN.

The letter described a negative home test, but the questionnaire left the result blank and a letter never fills an answer. A UM Nurse Reviewer asked for the result; the office answered Negative within the 14 calendar days, the criterion was then met, and the request was approved.